

THEORY OF KNOWLEDGE 2

19/02/2025

Wednesday

- What we know
- The (physical) processes of knowledge
- Philosophical studies on knowledge

20/02/2025

Thursday

Very brief introduction to the origins of epistemology.

Influence of science in philosophy and epistemology, today's philosopher is very much convinced that **it would be a better idea to study perception** itself.

"The 'in' and 'out' in the epistemic journey of human."

Out → Nature, perceptible world, later writing, social contact, quantum computers.

In → Inside the conscience

AI and out storage of information/knowledge.

-Black-boxing of AI

Perception and Plato

26/02/2025

Wednesday

J. LOCKE – For detailed understanding: <https://iep.utm.edu/locke-ep>

Background: Descartes declaring that universe is a machine mind/soul is not a part of it.

Descartes: The mind knows best its contents

Rationalism

vs

Empiricism

(Reason as source)

(Relying on data through senses)

Mind can be modelled

Not too interesting

An epistemological issue:

-How is our mind at birth?

An ontological question:

-What are the qualities/properties of objects?

Aristotle's substances -ousia- in regards to Descartes (*Cartesian dualism*).

Different nomological natures.

Nomological → Laws of operation

27/02/2025

Thursday

J. LOCKE

*Ontological question: What do we mean by "qualities ↔ properties (*same thing*) of objects"?

-Gold is a shiny thing

-God has atomic number of 79

*Sources of knowledge: (1) Sensation, (2) Reflection (*Thinking, Doubting, Believing, Perceiving, Reasoning, Willing*)

→ (all ideas can be traced back to these two)

Ideas are immediate objects of perception or thought or understanding

*And the power to produce an idea in the mind is called a **QUALITY**.

(A snowball has the power to produce in us the ideas of cold, white, round...)

*Primary qualities are inseparable from objects

(Mass, extension, figure)

*Secondary qualities are not in objects but they are powers to produce sensations in us by their primary qualities

*Powers in objects cause changes by means of the primary qualities of another object.

-Primary qualities resemble aspects of objects

-Secondary qualities do not.

****Do senses give accurate info about the world, or is it our mental creation only?***

Locke: There are several considerations:

(1) Our organs cannot produce "vision in the dark". We cannot smell roses in a desert.

(2) I cannot affect my perception when I look at the sun. (*I cannot deny the fact that I perceive the sun and not the moon*)

In those cases "imagination" and "perception"

differs.

(3) I can remember pain without the physical discomfort (*both mental*).

(4) If you doubt it [3], if you think that it is a creation of your mind, put your hand into fire.

05/03/2025

Wednesday

G. BERKELEY

Ontological: materialism-idealism

Epistemological: empiricism-rationalism

Like his predecessors: Epistemology begins with the mental content.

Objects of knowledge:

- Ideas imprinted on sense
- Those perceived by attending to the operations of mind
- Those formed by memory/imagination

- In addition to ideas, there must be "spirit", ideas cannot exist alone
 - *Discussion on mind, spirit, and soul.
- Existence of "unthinking [unthought/unperceived] things"?
- Contradiction about material substance
- Conceiving objects is distinct from perception?
- But isn't it true that our ideas resemble (external) objects?
- Locke's primary qualities

- "Change the sense organs, and primary qualities change."*

Discussion on sensible objects, can one perceive an unperceived tree? -Esse est percipi

06/03/2025

Thursday

BERKELEY

- *Ontology: minds(spirits) and ideas
- *Esse est percipi
- *"exist": defined through possibility of perception.
- *There is a contradiction about asserting the existence of matter independent of perception.
- *Try to separate the being of a sensible object from its being perceived
- *Why not say that our ideas resemble objects which are material?
- *Q: If there were "material objects" could we know them (as they are)?
- *Locke's primary qualities?
- *Change your sense organs, you will get a different extension
- *Ex: The same object feeling cold and warm to different hands if you immerse them in different containers. Why not the same with extension?

Berkeley: my argument primarily shows something about knowledge.

Knowing matter, how? → reason

→ senses

-Ex: in dreams we have the vision without (material) object

- "But it can exist probably". Then we admit we may never know them. So god creating stuff without purpose.

- I alone cannot create what I see at will.

- There is a rerum natura

STACE's Phenomenalism

In modern philosophical use, the term *phenomena* means things as they are experienced through the senses and processed by the mind as distinct from things in and of themselves.

- A problem about inferring existence of hypothetical entities like e^- through causal connection to visible world.

- That causation cannot be established.

Ex: the Sun is heating up objects → a piece of wax melts

(A) (B)

Subatomic event 1 occurs → subatomic event 2 occurs
which causes (A) which (causes B)

- Causation is observed at a phenomenal level
- We have no evidence for **II** above
- "Subatomic talk" is useful for theorizing only. Similarly with "force" we don't need to postulate "existence"
- Hence, the only cause of sensations are other sensations.
- Only sensations and minds exist. We don't need to admit existence of underlying level.

12/03/2025

Wednesday

WHITELEY (CONTEMPORARY PHENOMENALISM)

Representationalism (Lockian) - Phenomenalism (Berkeley-kind)

- **Sense-Data:** Sensory units of immediate awareness
(cognitively simple items)

- This terminology may allow us to talk about objects without "physicality"

- Phenomenalism: All statements about material objects can be completely analysed into statements about sense-data (reduction)

Advantages: Removing doubts!

Disadvantages: (1) We draw a distinction between appearance and reality
(2) Sense-data are transient; material objects are stable

J.S. Mill:

- Sense-data can be actual and possible

- Matter can be understood as the permanent possibility of sensation

(3) Material objects are causally active.

What about sense-data?

Case: Hume's analysis of causation: -invariable sequence

-regular repetition

-So causation is a relation among sense-data

A case: "S is bored now, but she is not showing any signs of it."

13/03/2025

Thursday

B. RUSSEL (Representationalism)

-objectivist → max (All is non-subjective)

→ min (Something is objective)

-subjectivist → max (All is subjective)

→ min (Something is not objective)

**Locke and Kant denied MAX*

-Russell: World → physiology → mental content

-Because of this our perceptions are similar (While there are subjective differences)

-A "percept" is an immediately given, and the most reliable part of knowledge.

It is subjective (non-shareable). It provides a basis or foundation.

So we can construct the "world", using inferences:

Ex: the distant objects are not actually small
(thus, we correct our perception)

-**physical** (publicly available) vs **perceptual** space

-What we see is not there "as it appears"

-Our perceptions need not reflect reality (like a mirror)

-When we examine human brain (where our mental content is occurring / we are examining something physical)

-That must be happening in physical space; and the perceptual space is created.

Representationalism: We perceive/experience our representations.

We mentally represent objects out there

Phenomenalism: We perceive/experience our representations.

But no inference from them to objects out there

Direct realism: We perceive objects.

We have visual experience of objects.

We do not see our experiences.

19/03/2025

Wednesday

INTENTIONALITY OF PERCEPTION

*Human cognition is a dynamic one, comprising representational and non-representational aspects.

(NETWORK) ↔ (BACKGROUND)

interaction

*Experience in general and perceptual experience are different performances. Experience does not only imply success: perception does.

*"But in a hallucination too we see objects."

*Intentionality as a quality of perception.

*Directedness of the mind, the quality of aboutness.

*Ex: -a sentence is about a situation

-a cat isn't

*Intentionality ~ intention

Something being about something is an example as to things being about things.

*Perception is always of objects (hence, "success")

*Tradition: object perceived

Contemporary: perception of states-of-affairs

S is P

*Visual experience(perception) has conditions of satisfaction

So it is similar to beliefs (turning into knowledge)

*This is how we explain intentionality in perception

20/03/2025

Thursday

J. SEARLE be careful about the difference between intentionality and intensionality

- *The intentional content provides the conditions of satisfaction for perception.
- *Intentionality is a concept of philosophy of mind.
- *Searle's view is further supplemented by Intensionality (a concept of philosophy of language)

*extension of a term: what satisfies it in the world
intension of a term: the sense/meaning of the term

*co-extensionality: -different term, but common extension
-can be exchanged in propositions without changing truth-value

Ex: morning star, Venus

Searle: Perception occurs in intensional context, not extensional

Ex: -in a town [bank manager] is also [tallest guy in town]

-suppose John is observing the B.M. John doesn't know the above "identity"

EXTENSIONAL: [John sees B.M.], hence, [John sees the tallest guy]

INTENSIONAL: John sees that [the B.M. is standing in front of a building]

→ ? John sees that [the tallest guy is standing in front of a building]

Searle says no.

*The asymmetry shows that we perceive aspects of things (not objects simpliciter)

*The aspect we experience in a given case has to do with the states-of-affairs we face.

-Further sophistications

1- When perception happens, it is causally self-referential → the cause is really what you find in the intentional content

Ex: John looking at the garden. Thinks he sees a white sheep at the far corner
Actually he is looking at the white rock. But, there is a white sheep behind the rock he is seeing.

→ John perceives that [there is a white sheep at the corner of the garden]
intentional content, **TRUE**

2- Perception and belief have a Mind→World direction of fitting. Desire is not like that.

A TABLE OF

COMPARISON: M: Mind, W: World, → : to

	<u>PERCEPTION</u>	<u>BELIEF</u>	
<u>DESIRE</u>			
<u>PRESENTATION/REPRESENTATION</u>	presentation	representation	
representation			
<u>CAUSALLY SELF-REFERANCIAL</u>	yes	no	no
<u>DIRECTION OF FIT</u>	$M \rightarrow W$ ^{to}	$M \rightarrow W$ ^{to}	
$W \rightarrow M$ ^{to}			

-complications: What happens if the object of perception is not "stable"

insert duck-rabbit figure here (the ambiguous figures)

-pattern recognition

09/04/2025

Wednesday

TWO EXAMPLES (challenges due to illusions)

1 - IOOI

("TOOT, table with 2 cylinders, 1001 with a top line")

- The same stimulus from an optic point of view
- The same conditions of satisfaction in the visual experiences
- But different visual experiences (due to different backgrounds)

2- The Moon Illusion

- Perceiving that the Moon changes its size
- Content of visual experience: Moon is changing size
- Content of my belief: Moon is **not** changing size
- Two different conditions of satisfaction
 - for perception
 - for (empirical) belief
- In other words, we must perceive that the Moon is changing size
- Rational "correction"

Perception isn't just physiological, societal factors also have an effect on it.

For the midterm make sure that you've completely understood these three point of views regarding perception and compare them.

Midterm only includes perception.

10/04/2025

Thursday

EPISTEMIC JUSTIFICATION

* $KsP \leftrightarrow BsP \wedge JsP \wedge P$

$\wedge \rightarrow$ the element of rationalization

*Are the three conditions sufficient

*Theories of Justification → foundationalism
→ coherentism

*Descartes' journey: Methodical doubt, the question of "how we grasp the identity of objects?"

"which mental faculty is responsible for that?"

- What happens once you show that "I" must exist?
- "Contents of the mind"
- There must be some cause behind the generation of ideas
(Can it be "I" especially in critical cases?)

MIND — MATTER

- Nomologically different substances

Descartes regarding foundationalism, why is he a pillar of it?

17/04/2025

Thursday

R. AUDI (*non-traditional foundationalism*)

-Traditional foundationalism: Cartesianism

-Difference of the contemporary literature: shifting emphasis from mental states to propositions

-Perceptual vs. inferential beliefs

→ a logical notion

→ arriving at a proposition from the consideration of premises

Ex: I believe that this rose I am perceiving is yellow

-The inflation rate of this year will be 50%

-What is the status of the majority of our beliefs in this regard?

Ex: I hear a key turning inside the lock of my house

-The idea of an "~~epistemic~~ justificatory chain"

Possibilities

(1) Going infinitely

(2) Circle onto itself

(3) terminate at non-J Bs

(4) terminate at JBs where J does not arise out of other Bs

^^^

CHAIN

$B_1 \leftarrow J \leftarrow B_2 \leftarrow J \leftarrow B_3 \dots \leftarrow B_i \leftarrow J^?$

Could include a starting point of justification

07/05/2025

Wednesday

R. AUDI

- Inferential connection in Justification
- Coherence (circle) vs foundationalism (basis)
- Foundation may even be unjustified
 - Inference may be inductive
- The total picture may be more realistic

BONJOUR

- Foundationalism vs coherentism
 - base beliefs not justified by other beliefs
- Externalism vs internalism
 - About the role of the knower
- Foundational (basic) beliefs are like Aristotle's "unmoved movers"
- Foundationalism is attractive for it seems to stop the J-chain.
- The question of "epistemic responsibility"
- Is it enough to say "B is basic?" Should S have an awareness of it?
What if S has no idea about it?

*But such (sometimes meta-level) beliefs come into the game and destroy the idea that Bs are not J-ed by other beliefs.

2 Types of Foundationalism:

1) Externalism

- S does not possess the justifying element at all
- We only require that S is justified, as a matter of fact
- It is a causal process alone

2) Givenism → Bonjour says this is more interesting

- S has the justifying element in question, but only in the form of "immediate apprehension", not full (cognitive) belief.

I perceive that this flower is blue

- My eyes are functioning
- Lighting is not misleading
- My brain is working properly

*D.M. Armstrong

- Thermometer view
- Externalism

08/05/2025

Thursday

L. BONJOUR

* Externalism: What causes also justifies

* Givenism: Here too are relations of causation. But ultimately what justifies is not totally external.

-Can givenism be defended as a better version of Foundationalism?

-Question: What exactly is the status of the "given"?

-A dilemma: Is the "given" a (high level) cognitive state

→ Yes (that-p) Given can provide J for B but will require S itself

→ No (not that-p) Doesn't require J for B but also won't give J to B

-Conclusion: No B which doesn't require justification from other beliefs.

Coherentism+Internalism (including perception)

-Non-linear structure in coherentist Justification

-Crux: -Causation may explain the origin (or source) of Bs

-But cannot explain J of B which requires reason.

-Cause vs reason

F. McGREW (*Classical Foundationalism*)

-Audi was wrong in being "moderate"

-Bs are by definition not inferentially connected to other beliefs

-But Audi thinks Bs can be "probabilistic" rather than certain

-Probabilistic means "conditional on other beliefs"

-So we can not call them "basic"!

-Possible counter argument: The faint perception of x

P: "I seems to see x"

McGrew: That position need not be probabilistic. One can be certain that p!

-In other words, not expressions of perception but cases of "how things seem to S" may have certainty, and that is the idea behind "being basic".

-But we can be wrong about "seeming to have headaches"

-McGrew: "Headaches have no hidden natures"

-Consider the following: 1) There is a blue object in front of me

2) I am currently perceiving a blue object in front of me.

3) I seem to see a blue object in front of me. → There is no inferential tie to get this. It is immediate and not probabilistic.

15/05/2025

Thursday

AN INTRO TO FEMINIST THEORY

Misconceptions:

-by females, for females

-equality of females → equality may not always be the case when regarding feminism → "Maternal thinking" being superior to "Paternal thinking".

-dominant view in the west

History:

-Hypatia (400 A.D.)

-M. Wollstonecraft (1792)

-A must reading: Schopenhauer's "On Women"

Principally: Centred on oppression, inequality, and disadvantages cause by patriarchal societies.

-Phenomenological/ideological determination of the subject. The notion of subjective constitution and problem of self-realization.

Major sorts:

-Liberal

-Marxist

-Radical

-2 discourses → descriptive

→ normative

*Sandra Bartky on "Psychological Oppression" → it is different from political or economic oppression.

*Bartky uses Frantz Fanon's (1925-1961) work on colonialism and oppression on black people.

Fanon's analysis of black oppression:

-racism yields political oppression along three pivotal dimensions:

(1) Stereotyping: "Black people are child-like" → not sufficient rationalization
→ closer to nature

(2) Cultural domination: Blacks too adopt discriminatory cultural codes created by white people and live by them.

(3) Sexual objectification: -Sexual function is separated from the rest and becomes representative of the person.

-Black are more "body" than "mind" or "spirit"

Bartky:

-The resultant oppression of blacks/women is not accidental, it is systematic, wide-spread, and generally held at a non-conscious modes.

21/05/2025

Wednesday

S. BARTKY

- Stereotyping
- Cultural domination
- Sexual objectification

*Specific focus on "how women should look"

*Ideal jobs for "ideal woman"

*The system can always turn to "historical/scientific facts" to affirm the proper role of females.

*"Why no great composers?"

*A produced female self dominates and suppresses an "authentic self"

➤Stereotyping regarding certain things → childlike, emotional

→ This caused the initial analysis of blacks to think that they were inferior to whites

Females also adopted a similar perspective, thinking that they were inferior to males. This is not merely cognitive, there also is a spiritual missing piece.

Blacks are identified with their body, for females it may be like the function of giving birth.

This system overall places unrealistic demands on females regarding how they should look.

→ All females thus should strive to look in this way. (Form cracker example)

Standards of beauty artificially changing (getting imposed.)

"Females are better suited for being nurses, or elementary school teachers."

History of opportunity.

There WERE great female composers.

K. Popper's confirmation theory (bias)

Persona creation

L. CODE (Taking Subjectivity Into Account)

*Determination of necessary/sufficient conditions is not the end of the philosophical self.

*Human knowledge is a social construct.

Hence, issues about making "universal claims"

*The subject of the JTB analysis is a **specific being**: "artificially isolated and purified individuals" → white males of a certain class

*Essential formulas aim to transcend contingencies. There, one subject is replaceable with another.

*Historically there were alternative approaches: -stoics

-Marxists

-phenomenologists

-pragmatists

-pragmatists

-followers of Wittgenstein

(all)->"Knowledge is

not a disinterested engagement"

***Code** claims that **gender** (correct definition of gender, toplumsal cinsiyet) is a category that must be considered in analyses.

*Our formulations of knowledge must take it into account.

22/05/2025

Thursday

L. CODE (Subjectivity)

- *Gender-neutrality cannot be defended: gender is relevant to knowledge.
- * "Constructive reorientation"
- *Is it subjectivism?
- *An enlightened view balancing relativism and realism.
- *Is reality a conceptual construction?

Extremes: -positivism

-full relativism

- *in traditional epistemological analyses, there is already an implicit bias.
- * "white males of a certain class"
- * "Women are not the best model for 'knowers'"
- *Scientific support in traditional thinking.
 - "excessive intellectual activity of women interferes with the proper function of uterus"
- *Is propositional knowledge the only kind? (objectifiable)
- *Pragmatism and feminism
 - "we groups of Rorty"

Crux

- *Knowledge is circumstantial, but circumstances can lie beyond "us".

28/05/2025

Wednesday

"Are 'Old Wives'-Tales' Justified?" (Dalmiya & Alcoff)

- Old Wives'-Tales: Beliefs on childbearing, reasoning, herbal medicines, good cooking.

-Problem: How to apply the universal criteria of goodness?

-Dalmiya and Alcoff: A more egalitarian approach

-Exclusion of non-propositional knowledge is both politically incorrect and epistemologically misleading.

-Q: Can housewives be genuine epistemic agents?

Ex: (Act of) soothing an upset baby or baking well.

Analogy: Making good jokes.

-History of midwives in Europe

-Even modern doctors recognise their practise as successful.

-Mostly illiterate, hence transmitting knowledge only orally; not through text.

-Their work went beyond mere "superstition".

-Involving empathy, sensitivity, dealing with fears, support etc.

→ Hence association with "subjectivity"

-Contrast: Objectivity of male doctors at hospitals

A paper: Nagel T. "What is it like to be a bat?"

→ "species-specific knowledge"

→ Similarity: gender-specific knowledge

29/05/2025

Thursday

Sorts of Knowledge (Dalmiya & Alcoff)

- Species-specific knowledge, gender specific knowledge.
- Not only physiological similarity but also social-cultural factors
- It can be expressed in propositions too, but not in a gender-neutral language
- But is skill really knowledge?
- Both propositional and know-how admit degrees.
- Personal Note: Baç & Irmak (2011), "Knowing Wrongly"
- Propositional knowledge is not a black-white affair either
- proposition → truth-value
- know-how → success

- Example: Quality of care given to a baby
- D&A: even though skill-knowledge may involve propositions, it cannot be reduced to propositional structures
- Arriving at facts is not the whole aim of human knowledge.
- *Therefore, knowledge in general has a subjective side, but it is not haphazard.
- *right/wrong still applies to human knowledge
- *G-experiential knowledge has the character of "collective privacy"
- *Epistemic norms are inevitably plural.